

A new constitution

Although Jefferson can readily be considered the guiding spirit behind the Declaration of Independence, he played no formal role in the drawing up of the next great document that shaped the nation: its Constitution. The United States was legally able to assert its independence from Britain in 1783. But for the next four years, it existed in an increasingly unstable political vacuum, its fate decided by an ever-more divided Confederation Congress, meeting variously in Pennsylvania, New York, and New Jersey.

There were serious reasons to believe the new nation might fail, torn apart by those arguing for the primacy of the rights of the individual states over the central government, and those in favor of a strong central government or even the creation of an American monarchy. In the spring of 1787, a Constitutional Convention took place in Philadelphia. The written, formalized Constitution proposed would not be provisionally ratified until June the following year, and then only after prolonged disputes. The result was an assertion of a new form of government. It was both a bill of rights and a blueprint for an ideal government, whose three branches—executive, legislative, and

“The god who gave us life, gave us liberty at the same time.

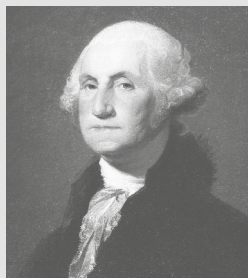
Thomas Jefferson”

judiciary—would keep each other in check. It would have a profound influence on that issued in Revolutionary France in 1791 and remains a model of its kind.

“Unfinished business”

The founding fathers were rightly optimistic about the United States’ potential, but they had failed to resolve one crucial question. Jefferson’s first draft of the Declaration of Independence called slavery “an execrable commerce” and “a cruel war against human nature itself.” However, to placate the slave states of the South and the slave traders of the north, these radical statements were later dropped. Almost 90 years later, it would take a civil war and 620,000 dead to end the practice and complete what Abraham Lincoln saw as the “unfinished business” of the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution. ■

George Washington



Born in 1732, George Washington served the British crown with distinction during the Seven Years’ War

(1756–1763) against France. He represented Virginia in the House of Burgesses and in the Continental Congresses of 1774 and 1775. With the outbreak of the American Revolution, he was the unanimous choice to lead the Continental Army, which he did with imagination and great fortitude, especially in the very difficult early years of the conflict: his “skeleton of an army,” under-equipped and close to starving, was forced to endure an exceptionally harsh winter in 1777–1778 at Valley

Forge in Pennsylvania. From 1783, Washington sought to establish a constitutional government for the new nation. The nation’s first president, he served two terms, retiring in 1797 in the face of increasing disputes between Jefferson’s Democratic Republicans and the Federalists, who were led by the quick-tempered Alexander Hamilton. Washington died in 1799 and was buried at his Virginia plantation, Mount Vernon, overlooking the Potomac River.